HEALING TOUCH
PM Narendra Modi visits injured victims at the LNJP Hospital in Delhi, Nov. 12

Pandey believes they should now focus on beefing up intelligence and conducting nationwide operations to crack down on Faridabad-like modules that may have sprouted in and around major cities. The Delhi blast has put Kashmiri doctors under the security lens, especially those working in different places. Several states and Delhi have reportedly begun such profiling. The managements of the GMCs in Srinagar and Anantnag have ordered doctors to identify and label their lockers within three days. "Radicalisation, brainwashing or extremist drift are often discussed in the context of various professions, but it is difficult to reconcile such outcomes with someone who has spent years in rigorous medical training, dedicated to saving lives," says Aaqib Ali Khan, a GMC doctor.

WITH DONALD TRUMP WARMING UP TO PAKISTAN, INDIA THIS TIME IS FIRST GATHERING PROOF BEFORE CONTEMPLATING AN OPERATION SINDOOR-LIKE RETALIATION

While both PM Modi and home minister Amit Shah said the perpetrators and masterminds of the heinous Delhi attack would be brought to book, the Indian government has avoided jumping the gun to point fingers immediately at Pakistan. Though it has said it will treat every terror attack as an act of war, the government has wisely decided to piece together all evidence before taking any action. Says MP-IDSA's counter-terrorism expert Adil Rasheed, "They are handling the Delhi blast investigation very methodically, which is reassuring. We don't know just how deep the rabbithole goes and investigators are trying to get a full picture of Pakistan's involvement and then sharing the findings with the international community. They seem to have learnt from Op Sindoor where India did not seem prepared for the international response, which, despite decades of Pakistan's terror record, treated it like a two-sided affair, with even the US response being mixed."

Moreover, with US president Donald Trump enhancing US-Pak relations for larger geopolitical gains, India may find itself isolated if it takes punitive action across the border akin to Op Sindoor. With Asim Munir consolidating his position by getting Parliament to pass a constitutional amendment making him chief of defence forces overseeing all the three armed forces, he has emerged even more powerful and beyond rational bounds. He seems ready to go higher in the escalation curve to invite American intervention which is why India, experts say, should play its cards carefully and ensure the international narrative is strongly on its side. "Munir is clearly trying to provoke India and getting us to come hammer and tongs at him so that he can cry wolf again to the international community," says Rasheed. "I am sure India understands his game plan and is doing its homework before retaliating." Rather than resort to what security experts call "performative militarism", including spectacular cross-border strikes, they advocate a long-term policy of "escalation dominance" that employs credible, repeatable ways including kinetic options to impose heavy costs on Pakistan, while staying below nuclear thresholds.

Another imperative for the Indian government is to plug governance gaps and make it difficult for Pakistan to radicalise professionals in Kashmir. As Swain says, "The attack reiterates that if you offer, and maintain, peace and an enabling environment to the common man in the Valley, he would get busy earning a livelihood that gives him self-worth and dignity and not allow himself to become cannon fodder for Pakistan's nefarious games." This requires India to step up its development plans for the state besides keeping a tight vigil on attempts from across the border to pull them into terror activities. In an interview to India Today TV, J&K chief minister Omar Abdullah pointed out how even three days after the strike, the central government did not think it fit to brief him or elicit his views. Whatever the reason, it's important for India to build the right narrative, especially in the Valley. Restoring statehood has been a long-pending demand. While experts like Rasheed caution against doing so immediately, others say the government would do well to lay down a roadmap. In tough times like these, what is needed is clarity of purpose and unity in action. ■

—with Kaleem Geelani in Srinagar